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(Mis)use of definition in Chinese EFL postgraduate students' academic writing: A local grammar based investigation

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ABSTRACT

Adopting a local grammar approach, the present study investigated Chinese EFL learners' use of the discourse act of definition in academic writing. A corpus of MA theses by Chinese EFL learners and a corpus of published research articles by expert writers in the field of Applied Linguistics were compiled for the current investigation. Instances of definition were retrieved by searching for a set of lexico-syntactic markers, and the subsequent local grammar analyses of these instances identified 26 highly frequent patterns associated with definition. Results showed that the Chinese EFL learners used substantially more definitions in their MA theses than expert writers did in research articles. Furthermore, subtle yet notable similarities and differences were observed between the two groups of writers' performance of definition at both the lexical-grammatical and discourse-semantic levels. It was argued that these observations not only bring us to a more nuanced understanding of the Chinese EFL learners' use of definition in academic writing, but also provide important insights into EAP writing research and pedagogy in EFL contexts.

1. Introduction

This study presents a local grammar based investigation into Chinese English as a foreign language (EFL) learners' use of definition in MA theses. It belongs to an on-going project which systematically explores Chinese EFL learners' pragmatic performance of communicative or discourse acts in academic writing. The primary aim of the project is to diagnose Chinese EFL learners' problems or difficulties in performing such discourse acts and, ultimately, to provide suggestions for EAP writing pedagogy in EFL contexts (see also Su et al., 2022). Briefly, discourse acts here refer to those rhetorical or communicative functions (e.g., giving examples, defining terms/concepts and making comparison and contrast) that are frequently performed in academic writing contexts. Pragmatic performance, as the term is used in the present study, refers to how writers' use of discourse acts contributes to writer-reader interaction and, more importantly, the quality of their academic writing. We consider the use of discourse acts as pragmatic performance because the linguistic choices writers make to perform such acts will have an impact on the pragmatic or communicative effects between writers and readers.

Academic writing has always been a challenging task for EFL learners and thus has attracted much scholarly attention. Previous studies on EFL learners' academic writing mainly focused on lexico-grammatical features such as lexical bundles (e.g., Bychkovska & Lee, 2017; Wei & Lei, 2011), collocation (e.g., Parkinson, 2015; Qian, 2019), and syntactic complexity (e.g., Atak & Saricaoglu, 2021; Ortega, 2015), which have deepened our understanding of EFL learners' development of lexico-grammatical competence in meeting

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the challenges of academic writing. While in recent decades there have also been numerous attempts researching into the pragmatic dimensions of EFL learners' academic writing, these studies have been mainly concerned with the interpersonal features such as stance and voice (e.g., Hyland, 2004; Ivanič & Camps, 2001; Wu & Paltridge, 2021). In contrast, relatively less attention has been paid to EFL learners' use or performance of discourse acts in academic writing. Ren (2022, p. 20), based on a comprehensive review of studies on L2 pragmatic competence, similarly pointed out that L2 learners' "writing pragmatic competence remains under-researched". To bridge this gap, we attempt to probe into Chinese EFL learners' pragmatic performance of discourse acts in academic writing, aiming to explore the problems and challenges they might encounter in writing practice so as to seek possible solutions.

The rationale of the present study can be elaborated as follows. First, appropriate performance of discourse acts has been shown to be of paramount importance to academic writing, as they are not only essential for the construction and dissemination of disciplinary knowledge but also a determinant of the persuasiveness and accessibility of academic texts (see Hyland, 2007; Kääntä et al., 2018; Morton, 2020). Second, despite the importance, it has been often reported that EFL or novice writers tend to have problems or difficulties in performing such discourse acts. For instance, Hyland and Tse (2004) observed that students struggled with performing the act of expressing gratitude in acknowledgements of MA and PhD dissertations, primarily due to a lack of knowledge about the structures and expressions available to do so. Similarly, Hinkel (2004) and Paquot (2008) found that EFL learners rarely successfully employed the act of exemplification in writing tasks and had a far more limited repertoire of exemplifying phraseologies than their English L1 counterparts. In the case of definition, Nashaat-Sobhy and Llinares (2020) regarded it as a serious pedagogical concern, noting that students' performances of definition depend upon their knowledge of word meaning as well as the linguistic resources available to define. One possible reason for these difficulties is that such discourse acts have only been loosely discussed in existing EAP textbooks, i.e., these discourse functions are just mentioned but without detailed description of their realisational patterns (e.g., Fang, 2021; Jordan, 1999; Kirszner & Mandell, 2017). In consequence, there is a pressing need to systematically document and describe the linguistic resources that are available to perform such discourse acts and, based on the description, to further diagnose what problems EFL learners may have when performing them in academic writing.

To that end, the present study draws on insights from recent advances in learner corpus research, in particular the call for a function-to-form approach to analysing learner writing and a function-driven type of annotation of learner language (Callies, 2015; Durrant & Mathews-Aydınlı, 2011). For example, Callies (2015) argues that a function-to-form approach aims to "link the occurrence of particular language forms and the functions that they serve in discourse", thus making possible "the identification and documentation of a near-complete inventory of lexico-syntactic means used to express various communicative functions in discourse" (p. 53). Also, he emphasises that a function-driven annotation could deepen our understanding of "form-function mappings in discourse by accounting for unexpected, interlanguage-specific structures that are bound to occur in learner language" (Callies, 2015, p. 54). In a similar vein, Durrant and Mathews-Aydınlı (2011) argue for a function-first approach to studying formulaic language. They suggest that what language learners need to know is not the word sequences *per se*, but rather the functions they need to express and the forms that most appropriately fulfil those functions. They then stress the need "for an analysis which, rather than starting from linguistic forms, starts from semantic functions and works towards deriving the range of recurrent forms associated with those functions" (ibid, p. 61).

Aligning with these lines of inquiries, the present study adopts a function-to-form approach, i.e., local grammar (see Section 2), to examine Chinese EFL postgraduate students' pragmatic performance of discourse acts in academic writing, focusing specifically on the discourse act of definition. According to Dalton-Puffer, 2013, (p. 234), definition has the specific communicative intent of telling others "about the extension of an object of specialist knowledge". While the general consensus has been reached that definition is frequently performed by academic writers to explain words, ideas, concepts or to elaborate abstract notions or technical terms, it is actually a complex concept (see also Barnbrook, 2002; Darian, 2003; Flowerdew, 1992; Triki, 2019; Zhang & Su, 2022; Ädel, 2006). Therefore, for the sake of simplicity and clarity, we slightly narrow down the scope of 'definition' in the present study. Specifically, in this study we only consider as definition those instances which either illustrate technical terms, abstract concepts or specify the meanings of words, and stick strictly to this definition. In other words, descriptive or explanatory instances (e.g., *CDA is a research field which attracts linguists both at home and abroad*[1]) are not considered as definition, although they might look like one.

We focus on definition, on the one hand, because it constitutes a core function in academic writing and the use of definition is a prevalent phenomenon in scientific/academic discourses (Swales & Feak, 2012; Triki, 2019; Ädel, 2006). On the other hand, as Darian (2003, p. 47) pointed out, although defining words and concepts is one of the most important analytical skills, it has been "taught haphazardly, if at all". Indeed, as indicated in the review offered by Triki (2019) and Zhang and Su (2022), despite its importance in academic writing, definition in high-stakes academic genres has not been well researched and taught. Therefore, examining EFL learners' pragmatic performance of definition in academic writing is a worthwhile undertaking, which could offer important implications for the teaching of definition (and by extension other discourse acts) in EAP context.

We begin in the next section with a brief introduction to the local grammar approach to contrastive discourse studies in academic contexts. In Section 3, we introduce the corpora used in the current investigation and the methods for data retrieval and analysis. We then present the main findings of the study in Section 4 and discuss its potential implications for EAP writing research and pedagogy in Section 5. Section 6 concludes this paper.

[1] All the examples used in the present study were taken from the corpora introduced in Section 3.1.

2. Local grammar approach to contrastive academic discourse studies

As aforementioned, the present study employs a function-to-form approach, i.e., local grammar, to analyse Chinese EFL learners' academic writing. Local grammar, as noted in Hunston and Su, 2019, (p. 571), "is always a grammar of a discourse function". Each discourse act, as mentioned at the beginning of the paper, roughly corresponds to one discourse function, hence the compatibility of using local grammars to account for discourse acts in academic writing. What makes local grammar particularly useful for exploring discourse acts is its use of context-specific and transparent functional terminologies to analyse corresponding formal or syntactic units of instances realising a target discourse act (e.g., Su & Wei, 2018; Su & Zhang, 2020). For example, the instance *Antonymy refers to gradable opposites which are fully gradable and incompatible* … realises definition, and its local grammar analysis is presented in Table 1.

Table 1 illustrates the mapping of functional-pragmatic terms onto syntactic units in local grammar analysis. Specifically, *Antonymy* represents the term/concept being defined and *gradable opposites* the way how the term is defined; thus, they can be labelled 'Definiendum' and 'Definiens', respectively. Meanwhile, *refers to* functions to connect the two parts of this definition, and the *which*-clause specifies the limiting characteristics of the defined term, thus labelled 'Hinge' and 'Supporting statement', respectively (see Table 6 for more discussion about the terminologies). In other words, local grammar analysis requires the analysts to decode the semantic relationship between syntactic units and then analyse each target syntactic unit, which may range from words, phrases to clauses, with a term that can explicitly reflect its communicative or discourse function. This is the way that local grammar analysis is performed.

There is by now a substantial body of research that has adopted the local grammar approach to document and describe the realisation of discourse acts in various contexts, including evaluation (Hunston & Su, 2019), disclaiming (Cheng & Ching, 2018), exemplification (Su & Zhang, 2020), and definition (Barnbrook, 2002; Zhang & Su, 2022). These studies have demonstrated that the resulting local grammars not only contribute to the description of language in use, but could also be usefully applied to inform language teaching (Hunston & Su, 2019; Su & Zhang, 2020).

Of more relevance to the current investigation is local grammar's capacity to capture the underlying regularity of language use at the discourse-semantic level. Rather than simply counting the frequency of lexical markers that may signal a discourse act, local grammar is more concerned with the discourse-semantics of corresponding syntactic units in the context of the target discourse act. This kind of analysis, on the one hand, has shown that instances co-occurring with the same marker could realise distinct local grammar patterns. In the case of definition, for example, instances containing *define* realise several patterns, some of which are shown in Table 2.

On the other hand, instances co-occurring with different lexical markers may be analysed using the same local grammar pattern. For example, all the instances provided in Table 3, though signalled by different definitional verbs (i.e., *refer, mean, comprise,* and *define*), realise the same local grammar pattern (Definiendum – Hing – Definiens – Supporting statement).

The point of the above discussion is that local grammar offers a viable approach to quantify the realisational patterns of a given discourse act between different groups of writers or across different contexts, thereby facilitating contrastive academic discourse studies. For instance, Su et al. (2021) adopted the local grammar approach to trace the changing patterns of exemplification in Linguistics research articles, which showed that academic writers of Linguistics nowadays tended to exemplify in simpler and more explicit ways. In a more recent study, Su et al. (2022) further explored how Chinese English-major MA students differed from expert writers in their use of exemplification in academic writing. They found that, compared with expert writers, student writers showed a

Table 1
Local grammar analysis of definition.

Definiendum	Hinge	Definiens[1]	Supporting statement
Antonymy	*refers to*	*gradable opposites*	*which are fully gradable and incompatible …*

[1] As one reviewer pointed out, other researchers might consider '*gradable opposites … and incompatible*' to be the 'Definiens' that can be divided into 'Superordinate' and 'Discriminator'. To maintain consistency with our earlier work (Zhang & Su, 2022), however, we retain the terms 'Definiens' and 'Supporting statement' in the present study. See also Table 6 for more discussion about the terminologies used for the local grammar analysis of definition.

Table 2
Local grammar analyses of definitional instances co-occurring with 'define'.

Scope	Definiendum	Hinge	Definiens	Supporting statement
In this study,	*word form production*	*was defined*	*as the ability*	*to recall and spell target word forms correctly.*
Source-external	**Hinge**	**Definiendum**	**Definiens**	**Supporting statement**
Atkinson et al. *(2007)*	*defined*	*alignment*	*as 'the complex means*	*by which human beings effect coordinated interaction, and …*
Definiendum	**Hinge**	**Definiens**		
Phraseological knowledge	*can be roughly defined*	*as knowledge of formulaic sequences or multi-word expressions (MWEs).*		
Definiendum	**Hinge**	**Definiens**	**Source-external**	
Difficult	*can be defined*	*as 'needing skill or effort'*	*(Cambridge Dictionary)*	

Table 3
Local grammar analyses of instances co-occurring with different definitional verbs.

Definiendum	Hinge	Definiens	Supporting statement
The so-called hard-context	*refers to*	*the hardware of pedagogical context,*	*which is the material basis of teaching activities …*
"Guys"	*mean*	*a group of people*	*who are intimate with each other.*
Alignment	*comprises*	*the students' genre awareness*	*–the ability to use genre knowledge acquired in the course …*
Interactional competence	*may be defined*	*as that competence*	*which is specifically needed to interact …*

preference for using exemplification to specify superordinate categories or abstract concepts but tended to underuse the other major strategy of exemplifying by citing relevant studies.

From a methodological point of view, the two studies reviewed above have demonstrated the usefulness of local grammar descriptions in quantifying the realisational patterns of a given discourse act, facilitating contrastive investigation into the ways a discourse act can be performed across contexts or by different groups of writers. Therefore, the present study employs the local grammar approach to investigate Chinese EFL learners' use of definition in academic writing, with expert writers' use of definition in published research articles as reference for comparison (see Section 3). Our aim is to explore the extent to which Chinese EFL learners perform definition in ways that are similar to or different from those by expert writers and to further discuss the pedagogical implications for the teaching of definition and by extension other discourse acts in EAP contexts.

3. Corpora and methodology

3.1. Corpora

For the purpose of this study, two corpora were compiled from academic texts in the field of Applied Linguistics. One was compiled of 60 MA theses collected from the Applied Linguistics programme at universities in mainland China (hereafter COMATAL). These texts were obtained from CNKI (China National Knowledge Infrastructure; https://www.cnki.net/) where MA theses were uploaded after graduation and were made available to all subscribing universities, such that using these texts as data would not constitute any infringement of copyright. We chose to collect MA theses in Applied Linguistics because MA theses in this programme are required to be written in English (note that this does not apply to the other programmes in Chinese universities, except for a few universities offering EMI courses) and represent the most substantial piece of academic writing for Chinese EFL learners at the master's degree level. More notably, since MA students are advanced EFL learners who are competent at producing grammatically well-formed sentences and have relatively higher pragmatic competence, it can be argued that MA theses could provide useful data for investigating Chinese EFL learners' pragmatic performance of discourse acts in academic writing.

The other corpus, which was used as reference for comparison, was compiled of 100 published research articles by expert writers in the field of Applied Linguistics (hereafter CORAAL) and published in the journal *Applied Linguistics* (https://academic.oup.com/applij/). We selected these texts partly because published research articles are "commonly recognised as the model of academic writing" (Alangari et al., 2020, p. 4), and partly because the journal *Applied Linguistics* is regarded as one of the flagship journals and covers a wide range of topics in this discipline. The meta-information of the two corpora is given in Table 4.

At this point, it is worth pointing out that using MA theses and research articles as the data may raise issues concerning comparability. Specifically, there are two points of contrast between the two corpora. One relates to genre and the other to proficiency level. While bearing in mind that some differences might be attributable to genre variation, the current investigation focuses on differences in proficiency. This is because our aim has been to diagnose the Chinese EFL learners' problems or difficulties in performing discourse acts and, based on which, to further provide suggestions for teaching them in the Chinese EFL contexts. Therefore, our choice of using expert writers' published research articles as reference for comparison can draw support from Ädel (2006):

> … professional writing represents the norm that advanced learner writers try to reach and their teachers try to promote. In this respect, a useful corpus for comparison is one which offers a collection of what Bazerman (1994: 131) calls 'expert performances'.
>
> (Ädel, 2006, p. 207)

3.2. Data retrieval

We used *Sketch Engine* (https://app.sketchengine.eu/) to process the data and to retrieve instances of definition in the two corpora. First, drawing on insights from previous studies (e.g., Flowerdew, 1992; Pearson, 1998; Triki, 2019; Zhang & Su, 2022; Ädel, 2006), we

Table 4
Meta-information of the two corpora.

Corpora	No. of texts	No. of tokens	Average length
COMATAL	60	1,307,395	21,789.92
CORAAL	100	1,163,320	11,633.20

Table 5
Markers of definition and their frequency in the two corpora.

	Markers	COMATAL		CORAAL		LL	LR
		Raw	Normed[1]	Raw	Normed		
Definitional construction	'X BE Y' construction	543	415.33	95	81.66	+297.38 ****	2.35
Definitional nouns	term (as noun)	23	17.59	25	21.49	–0.48	–0.27
	concept	12	9.18	3	2.58	+4.78 *	1.83
	definition	39	29.83	6	5.16	+23.34 ****	2.53
	notion	8	6.12	5	4.30	+0.39	0.51
Definitional verbs	mean (as verb)	142	108.61	11	9.46	+118.22 ****	3.52
	refer	481	367.91	96	82.52	+237.49 ****	2.16
	consider	66	50.48	10	8.60	+39.89 ****	2.55
	call	107	81.84	25	21.49	+45.74 ****	1.93
	regard	55	42.07	8	6.88	+34.11 ****	2.61
	define	149	113.97	63	54.16	+26.59 ****	1.07
	consist of	44	33.65	6	5.16	+28.36 ****	2.71
	seen as	13	9.94	18	15.47	–1.50	–0.64
	known as	20	15.30	12	10.32	+1.20	0.57
	term (as verb)	26	19.89	4	3.44	+15.56 ****	2.53
	comprise	7	5.35	8	6.88	–0.23	–0.36
Linking adverbials	i.e.	15	11.47	33	28.37	–9.18 ****	–1.31
	that is	1	0.76	23	19.77	–27.61 ****	–4.69
	BE related to	2	1.53	2	1.72	–0.01	–0.17
	BE concerned with	36	27.54	1	0.86	+38.14 ****	5.00
	Total	1789	1368.37	454	390.26	+701.53 ****	1.81

Note: LL = log-likelihood value; LR = log ratio; '+' = overuse in COMATAL relative to CORAAL; '–' = underuse in COMATAL relative to CORAAL; * = $p < 0.05$; ** = $p < 0.01$; *** = $p < 0.001$; **** = $p < 0.0001$.
[1] The frequency was normalised per 1,000,000 million words throughout.

identified a set of lexical items and one syntactic construction that can signal the discourse act of definition. These lexico-syntactic markers of definition were classified into four broad categories, i.e., definitional construction, definitional nouns, definitional verbs, and linking adverbials (see also Zhang & Su, 2022). We then searched for these items and their possible variants in the two corpora, and carefully examined the hits returned by the search to make sure that all the instances to be analysed are definitions. Log-likelihood values were tested using Paul Rayson's online calculator (http://ucrel.lancs.ac.uk/llwizard.html) to identify statistical differentiation of the markers used by the Chinese EFL learners and the expert writers. The quantitative information of each marker is presented in Table 5.

A few caveats need to be mentioned. First, since we used computerised search to retrieve data, we have not been able to consider covert definitions (i.e., those not signalled by any formal markers). Second, we observed that some definitional instances may contain two or more definition markers; for example, the instance *Our definition of collocational accuracy refers to how accurate learners are in producing acceptable and expected multiword units* (CORAAL) has '*definition*' and '*refer*'. To avoid repetition, such instances were analysed and counted only once.

With regard to these markers, Table 5 shows that the Chinese EFL learners used the majority of the markers statistically more frequently than the expert writers did, resulting in more definitions in COMATAL than in CORAAL. In particular, they relied heavily on

Table 6
Terminologies for a local grammar analysis of definition (adapted from Zhang & Su, 2022).

Terminology	Explanation	Example
Definiendum	The syntactic unit that indicates the term or concept being defined.	*Extrinsic modality* refers to assessments of likelihood (Biber et al., 1999: 485).
Definiens	The syntactic unit that indicates how the term or concept is defined or refers to the superordinate term that is being specified by additional linguistic element.	Phraseological knowledge can be roughly defined *as knowledge of formulaic sequences or multi-word expressions (MWEs)*.
Source-internal	The syntactic unit that attributes the source of the definition to the current author(s).	*We* call the negative end of this dimension 'Completed Events'.
Source-external	The syntactic unit that attributes the source of the definition to previous literature or other researcher(s).	*Atkinson* et al. *(2007)* define alignment as 'the complex means by which …
Hinge	The syntactic unit that links different parts of a definition.	Slang *is* a nonstandard vocabulary …
Initiator	The syntactic unit that indicates the act of definition is going to be performed.	*The term* 'interaction' is used to describe the entire online engagement …
Scope	The syntactic unit that delimits the extent to which the definition is valid or applicable.	*In this article,* we use the term storytelling to refer to a stretch of talk to which …
Supporting statement	The syntactic unit that further specifies the limiting features of the term or concept being defined or provides additional information.	Collocation is usually defined as a relation *in which a collocate may be positioned either before or after the node and does not*

Table 7
An overview of local grammar patterns of definition identified in both corpora.

Set	No.	Pattern					
Set 1	**PA1**	**Definiendum** *Alignment*	**Hinge** *refers to*	**Definiens** *the students' ability*	**Supporting statement** *to use their developing genre awareness to negotiate the conventions …*		
	PA2	**Definiendum** *A conceptual metaphor*	**Hinge** *is*	**Definiens** *a mapping between two domains of experience …*			
	PA3	**Definiens** *These open-window transition periods*	**Hinge** *are often known as*	**Definiendum** *phase shifts.*			
	PA4	**Definiens** *This strategy*	**Hinge** *is called*	**Definiendum** *positive politeness*	**Supporting statement** *which is oriented toward the positive face of the hearer.*		
	PA5	**Definiens** *The process*	**Supporting statement** *where the learner attends to the linguistic features in the input during online comprehension and holds these in working memory*	**Hinge** *is called*	**Definiendum** *'intake'.*		
Set 2	**PA6**	**Definiendum** *Pan-familism*	**Hinge** *is*	**Definiens** *the expansion of cognitive models of FAMILY to the non-FAMILY collective groups*	**Source-external** *(Ren Hongshun, 2009).*		
	PA7	**Definiendum** *Variability*	**Hinge** *is defined*	**Definiens** *as "the property of language*	**Supporting statement** *that defines the range of possibilities from which choices can be made"*	**Source-external** *(Verschueren 1999).*	
	PA8	**Source-external** *Cowie and Bell (1996)*	**Hinge** *define*	**Definiendum** *formative assessment*	**Definiens** *as "the process*	**Supporting statement** *used by teachers and students to recognise and respond …*	
	PA9	**Source-external** *According to Li & Zhang (2009),*	**Definiendum** *individualism*	**Hinge** *is*	**Definiens** *the values of Western culture*	**Supporting statement** *largely embodied in the pursuit of free will …*	
	PA10	**Source-external** *Allport (1937)*	**Hinge** *used the term*	**Definiendum** *nomothetic*	**Hinge** *to refer to*	**Definiens** *the study of personality traits*	**Supporting statement** *that are shared by many people …*
	PA11	**Source-external** *Whaley (1997: 203)*	**Hinge** *defines*	**Definiendum** *tense*	**Definiens** *as "a grammatical expression of the relationship between two points in time".*		
	PA13	**Source-external** *Rosenzweig (1986: 242)*	**Hinge** *coined the term*	**Definiendum** *idiodynamic*	**Hinge** *to refer to*	**Definiens** *his focus on events as key to understanding personality.*	
	PA12	**Definiens** *Such a learner linguistic system*	**Hinge** *has been called*	**Definiendum** *interlanguage (IL)*	**Source-external** *(Selinker, 1972: 214).*		
	PA14	**Definiendum** *Face*	**Hinge** *is defined*	**Source-external** *by Brown and Levinson*	**Definiens** *as "the public self-image*	**Supporting statement** *that every member wants to claim for himself."*	
	PA15	**Source-external**	**Definiendum**	**Hinge**	**Definiens**		

(*continued on next page*)

Table 7 (*continued*)

Set	No.	Pattern				
		In Modern Chinese edited by Hu Yushu (1981:139)	*auxiliary verbs*	*are defined*	*as those indicating possibilities.*	
	PA16	**Source-external** *Récanati (2002)*	**Hinge** *calls*	**Definiens** *these inferential enrichments*	**Definiendum** *primary pragmatic processes.*	
	PA17	**Source-internal** *… we can generalize "proverb" as this:*	**Definiendum** *proverb*	**Hinge** *is generally refer to*	**Definiens** *as brief, witty sayings or refinements of the wisdom of the folk*	**Supporting statement** *that people find and …*
	PA18	**Definiens** *This communicated but unsaid material*	**Hinge** *is what*	**Source-external** *Grice*	**Hinge** *called*	**Definiendum** *conversational implicature.*
	PA19	**Definiens** *… a network of overlapping similarities,*	**Source-external** *which he*	**Hinge** *calls*	**Definiendum** *family resemblance.*	
Set 3	**PA20**	**Initiator** *The notion of*	**Definiendum** *alignment*	**Hinge** *refers to*	**Definiens** *to the coherence between the students' criteria for judgment and the actual requirements …*	
	PA21	**Initiator** *The word*	**Definiendum** *"predication"*	**Hinge** *refers to*	**Definiens** *to a basic process and result*	**Supporting statement** *which linguistically assigns certain qualities to …*
Set 4	**PA22**	**Scope** *And in this thesis,*	**Definiendum** *the meaning loss*	**Hinge** *is defined*	**Definiens** *as the lost proportion of the original information*	**Supporting statement** *caused by the cross-cultural differences …*
	PA23	**Scope** *In this case,*	**Definiendum** *compliments*	**Hinge** *are*	**Definiens** *complex speech acts.*	
	PA24	**Definiendum** *Long words*	**Hinge** *are defined*	**Scope** *here*	**Definiens** *as any word*	**Supporting statement** *whose length is greater than the mean word length of the corpus.*
	PA25	**Definiendum** *The Standard English*	**Scope** *here*	**Hinge** *refers to*	**Definiens** *Standard English in the grammatical and lexical aspects.*	
	PA26	**Definiendum** *Verb*	**Scope** *in English grammar,*	**Hinge** *refers to*	**Definiens** *the word*	**Supporting statement** *that serves as the predicate of a sentence …*

the X BE Y construction and definitional verbs but were less aware of using linking adverbials such as *i.e.* and *that is* when performing the act of defining. However, as we discussed in Section 2, simply counting the frequency of these markers may not reliably quantify the realisations of definition at the discourse-semantic level (see also Su et al., 2022). Therefore, in the next step, all the retrieved instances of definition were subject to local grammar analysis.

3.3. Local grammar analyses

For our analyses, we adapted the terminologies used in Zhang and Su (2022) which have been shown to be useful for local grammar analysis of definition in Linguistics research articles (cf., Flowerdew, 1992; Barnbrook, 2002; Triki, 2019). The terminologies are listed and explained in Table 6.

As noted in Section 1, unlike Zhang and Su (2022) who less strictly defined definition, in the present study we narrowed down the scope of definition to those instances in which there is a technical term or abstract concept or specific word that is being explicated. This helped us to more easily recognise 'genuine' definition instances. We then independently performed the local grammar analyses of all the definition instances identified in the two corpora. As a way of cross-checking, frequent debriefing sessions were held to resolve all our disagreement. In this way, the local grammar patterns of definition were established (see Table 7).

3.4. Statistical analysis

Results from the local grammar analyses of the two corpora were subject to comparison so as to pinpoint the similarities and differences between the Chinese EFL learners' and the expert writers' use of definition in academic writing. To this end, we again used Paul Rayson's log-likelihood (LL) calculator (see also Section 3.2) to test if the differences between the two corpora were statistically significant. The greater the log-likelihood (LL) value, the more significant the difference is. In what follows, we present the major findings and then discuss the implications for EAP writing research and pedagogy.

Table 8
Distribution of local grammar patterns of definition between the two corpora.

	Pattern	COMATAL		CORAAL		LL	LR	Code
		Raw	Normed	Raw	Normed			
Set 1	**PA1**	646	494.11	141	121.20	+294.76 ****	2.03	overuse
	PA2	335	256.23	59	50.72	+194.97 ****	2.39	overuse
	PA3	61	46.66	27	23.21	+9.81 **	1.01	overuse
	PA4	15	11.47	3	2.58	+5.56 *	1.74	overuse
	PA5	16	12.24	1	0.86	+14.27 ***	3.83	overuse
	Subtotal	1,073	820.72	231	198.57	+495.82 ****	2.05	overuse
Set 2	**PA6**	20	15.30	27	23.21	– 2.02	– 0.6	similar use
	PA7	52	39.77	19	16.33	+12.33 ***	1.28	overuse
	PA8	82	62.72	16	13.75	+34.06 ****	2.04	overuse
	PA9	80	61.19	9	7.74	+57.09 ****	2.98	overuse
	PA10	60	45.89	9	7.74	+36.5 ****	2.57	overuse
	PA11	30	22.95	9	7.74	+9.61 **	1.57	overuse
	PA12	14	10.71	6	5.16	+2.43	1.05	similar use
	PA13	32	24.48	5	4.30	+18.96 ****	2.51	overuse
	PA14	9	6.88	4	3.44	+1.43	1.00	similar use
	PA15	51	39.01	2	1.72	+50.9 ****	4.5	overuse
	PA16	13	9.94	1	0.86	+10.85 ***	3.53	overuse
	PA17	10	7.65	1	0.86	+7.53 **	3.15	overuse
	PA18	4	3.06	0	0	+5.09 *	2.83	misuse
	PA19	12	9.18	0	0	+15.28 ****	4.42	misuse
	Subtotal	469	358.73	108	92.84	+203.36 ****	1.95	overuse
Set 3	**PA20**	25	19.12	14	12.03	+1.99	0.67	similar use
	PA21	28	21.42	14	12.03	+3.27	3.27	similar use
	Subtotal	53	40.54	28	24.07	+5.20 *	0.75	overuse
Set 4	**PA22**	41	31.36	9	7.74	+18.61 ****	2.02	overuse
	PA 23	41	31.36	9	7.74	+18.61 ****	2.02	overuse
	PA 24	0	0	7	6.02	– 10.55 **	– 3.98	underuse
	PA 25	13	9.94	2	1.72	+7.78 **	2.53	overuse
	PA 26	14	10.71	1	0.86	+11.98 ***	3.64	overuse
	Subtotal	109	83.37	28	24.07	+42.17 ****	1.79	overuse
Set 5	**Other patterns**	85	65.01	59	50.71	+2.18	0.36	similar use
Total		1,789	1368.37	454	390.26	+701.53 ****	1.81	overuse

4. Results and discussion

4.1. Overall results

Our analyses identified 98 local grammar patterns of definition in the two corpora. However, there were 72 patterns that occurred rather infrequently in both corpora, i.e., less than five times per million words, and showed no statistically significant difference between the two corpora. Because of their low frequency and idiosyncrasy, these patterns were simply grouped as 'Other patterns'. The remaining 26 patterns were categorised into four sets according to their prototypicality and similarity (see Table 7). Briefly, the first set includes five patterns containing only the essential elements of definitions, i.e., Definiendum, Definiens, Supporting statement, and Hinge. The second set includes 14 patterns where there is an additional element specifying whether the definition is drawn from other sources (labelled 'Source-external') or formulated by the current author(s) (labelled 'Source-internal'). The third set includes two patterns in which the definitional act is initiated by a definitional noun (e.g., *the term/notion/concept*). The last set includes five patterns in which the definition is modified by an element 'Scope' delimiting the extent to which the definition is valid or applicable.

We then present the distribution of these patterns across the two corpora and the results of loglikelihood tests in Table 8. Based on the analyses, four codes were generated to describe the Chinese EFL learners' performance of definition in comparison with that of expert writers', namely, *similar use*, *overuse*, *underuse*, and *misuse*. '*Similar use*' refers to those cases in which there was no statistically significant difference between the two groups of writers (LL < 3.84), meaning that the Chinese EFL learners used these patterns as frequently as expert writers to perform the discourse act of definition in academic writing. We used the other two codes '*overuse*' and '*underuse*' to refer to those patterns whose frequency was significantly higher or lower in COMATAL than in CORAAL. Finally, those patterns which were frequently used by the learner writers but were not found in expert writing were coded as '*misuse*'. At this point, a caveat should be mentioned though. Our categorisation of the learner writers' uses of definition into the aforementioned four types was mainly based on the statistical differentiation of the frequency of each local grammar pattern between the two corpora; as a consequence, the question of to what extent the use of each pattern was appropriate in specific co-text and context remains to be addressed in future research.

Below we discuss some observations that can be tentatively drawn from our analyses. It should be cautioned that, as the current investigation focused specifically on the Chinese EFL learners, the observations discussed here may only be applicable to this specific group of EFL learners. First, it is evident that, overall, the Chinese EFL learners performed the discourse act of definition nearly four times more frequently in the MA theses than expert writers did in research articles (1,368.37 vs 390.26 per million words) and that the difference between the two groups of writers was extremely significant (LL $= 701.53$, $p < 0.0001$). Additionally, Table 8 also shows that the Chinese EFL learners used more frequently the majority of the patterns identified than their expert counterparts, which indicates that the overall higher frequency of definition was not an effect of more frequent use of a few individual patterns. A similar observation was made in Ädel, 2006, (p. 108) who, comparing EFL learners with native speakers, found that EFL learners used "at least three times as many terms of this category [definition] as the native speakers".

The Chinese EFL learners' overuse of definition could be possibly explained by the average length, structural organisation, and different readership of the two genres. First, an MA thesis is approximately twice the length of a research article (see Table 4) and, to EFL learners, definition is "a general writing strategy – a 'filler' strategy – to meet the size requirements of the writing task" (Ädel, 2006, p. 110). The second reason may be related to structural organisation. Specifically, there is usually a chapter dedicated to introducing the theoretical framework used in Chinese EFL learners' MA theses. To organise such a chapter well requires the MA students to frequently revisit and/or reinterpret the same theoretical concepts discussed by different scholars, resulting inevitably more definitions. Third, as the target readers of MA theses are mainly institutionally designated thesis examiners, the greater use of definitions allows the thesis writers to display their acquired knowledge of the fundamental concepts in the field, thereby giving the thesis "a philosophical touch" (Ädel, 2006, p. 110) and presenting themselves as qualified MA graduates. In contrast, the potential readers of published research articles are usually peer researchers and professionals with shared specialist knowledge. Thus, there is less need for expert writers to discuss definitions which have already been accepted as common knowledge in the disciplinary community. Additionally, the heavier use of definition by the Chinese EFL learners may be attributed to their preference for giving word definitions (e.g., *"同情" in Chinese originally means to feel or express compassion as for other people's sufferings*) or folk definitions (e.g., *English is a member of the Indo-European language family …)*, whereas these types of definitions were rarely found in expert writing. This finding corroborates Darian's (2003, p. 49) argument that "the complexity of a definition depends on the age, interests, purpose, and background knowledge of the audience. The less expert the audience, the greater your need to define, but the less technical your definition can be".

In addition to the general tendency that Chinese EFL learners tended to overuse definition in academic writing, some subtle yet

Table 9
Distribution of 'Source-external' and 'Source-internal' between the two corpora.

	COMATAL		CORAAL		LL	LR
	Raw	Normed	Raw	Normed		
Source-external	459	351.08	107	91.98	+196.64 ****	1.93
Source-internal	10	7.65	1	0.86	+7.53 **	3.15
LL	+553.43 ****		+138.36 ****		–	–
LR	5.52		6.74		–	–

notable similarities and differences can be further observed from a closer scrutiny of the respective distribution of local grammar patterns across the two corpora, which will be discussed in the subsequent sections.

4.2. Set 1: basic patterns of definition

The most frequent patterns for both the Chinese EFL learners and expert writers are PA1 (Definiendum – Hinge – Definiens – Supporting statement) and PA2 (Definiendum – Hinge – Definiens) in Set 1. These two patterns are the simplest and most prototypical patterns to realise definition, in which 'Definiendum' appears in the left part and 'Definiens' in the right part of a definition clause and the two parts are linked by a 'Hinge' (see also Zhang & Su, 2022). However, the analyses show that the learner writers used these two patterns much more frequently than expert writers and the differences were extremely significant (LL = 294.76, LL = 194.97, $p < 0.0001$), indicating that the Chinese EFL learners relied heavily upon these basic realisational patterns of definition and used them as default strategies to define terms or concepts in writing practice.

The other three patterns in Set 1, with 'Definiens' placed in the left part and 'Definiendum' in the right part, were used relatively less frequently by the two groups of writers. It was observed that the Chinese EFL learners overused all three patterns at different levels of statistical significance. It was particularly noteworthy that only one instance of PA5 (Definiens – Supporting statement – Hinge – Definiendum) was found in CORAAL (0.86 times per million words) but it occurred 12.24 times per million words in COMATAL and the difference was statistically significant (LL = 14.27, $p < 0.001$). In PA5, 'Definiens' and its 'Supporting statement' are presented as, in terms of Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL; Halliday & Matthiessen, 2014), the *Theme* in the definition clause, which serve as the point of departure of the message. However, as illustrated in Example (1), such pattern would result in a '*heavy head*' of the sentence. Arguably, this might explain why PA 5 was less favourable in professional writing and thus rarely found in CORAAL.

(1) … The address forms used for both sides of the conversation to get further understanding are called unmarked address forms. (COMATAL)

4.3. Set 2: attributing the definition to a source

Set 2 contains patterns in which the source of a definition is specified, which allows the writers to acknowledge the human agency in knowledge construction (Ivanič & Camps, 2001). We categorised these patterns into two subtypes, one attributing a definition to previous literature or other researchers, labelled 'Source-external', and the other to the authors themselves, labelled 'Source-internal'. To explore their respective uses of sources when performing the act of defining, we examined the distribution of local grammar patterns with 'Source-external' and those with 'Source-internal' across the two corpora, the results of which are presented in Table 9.

The results indicate that both groups of writers drew on definitions from external sources significantly more frequently than refer explicitly to themselves (LL = 553.43, LL = 138.36, $p < 0.0001$). The fact that both groups of writers preferred to draw on externally sourced definitions, on the one hand, may be due to the reiterative nature of knowledge construction in soft disciplines. That is, scholarship in soft disciplines – in this case Applied Linguistics – often readdresses similar topics or issues in the field, so that researchers often feel obliged to revisit and reinterpret materials previously studied and then take up a position in relation to the views of others (Becher & Trowler, 2001; Charles, 2006; Hyland, 2004). On the other hand, as Ivanič and Camps (2001) suggested, frequent references to previous literature and researchers position the writers as relatively tentative and deferential to the authority of others, while references to oneself using first-person pronouns (*I, we, my, me, us, our*) and expressions such as '*this author*', would present the writers as self-assured, asserting their own right to display disciplinary knowledge and understanding. This might also account for the learners' heavier use of the external sources when defining in their MA theses, as compared with expert writers (LL = 196.64, $p < 0.0001$).

Moreover, we observed that for expert writers, the most frequent patterns in this set are PA6 (Definiendum – Hinge – Definiens – Source-external) and PA7 (Definiendum – Hinge – Definiens – Supporting statement – Source-external), in which 'Source-external' occurs at the end of a definition, typically in parentheses, forming a non-integral citation (Hyland, 1999; Swales, 1990). Surprisingly, however, PA6 was slightly less used by the Chinese EFL learners, though with no statistical difference (LL = 2.02). Additionally, while the Chinese EFL learners used PA12 (Definiens – Hinge – Definiendum – Source-external) and PA14 (Definiendum – Hinge – Source-external – Definiens – Supporting statement) similarly with expert writers, they overused PA8, PA9, PA10, PA11, PA13, PA15, PA16, and PA17 at various levels of statistical significance. One commonality of these patterns lies in that the source of the definition, either external or internal, is put at the initial position of a definition clause, which normally form integral citations (Hyland, 1999; Swales, 1990) with the cited author within the sentence structure as subject (2), as part of a noun phrase (3), or as an adjunct (4).

(2) *Chu (1998)* defines a Chinese clause as "minimally consisting of a predicate of various forms". (COMATAL)
(3) *Mey's definition* as "Pragmatics studies the use of language in human communication as determined by the … (COMATAL)
(4) *According to Ellis (1994)*, crosslinguistic influence usually refers to the incorporation of features of the L1 into the knowledge systems of the L2 which the learner … (COMATAL)

The learner writers' overuse of these patterns seems to suggest that they are inclined to recognise the human agents (e.g., other researchers or the writers themselves) as responsible for the definition of a given term or concept. Furthermore, a closer examination of our data revealed that in a number of cases, the learner writers tended to present the source, either external or internal, in the form of a coordinate clause preceding the definition clause, as shown in Example (5).

(5) *The concept of diglossia was originally introduced by Ferguson (1959: 336) with the following definition*: Diglossia is a relatively stable language situation in which, in addition to the primary … (COMATAL)

Strictly speaking, the clauses that indicate the source also contain other functional elements such as 'Definiendum', 'Initiator' and 'Hinge'. However, considering that their primary function is to indicate the source to which the definition can be attributed, and in order not to complicate the analyses, we consider the whole clause as realising the source. Nevertheless, such practices of attribution, often resulting in lengthy definitions and lexical redundancy, were rarely found in CORAAL.

A third observation worthy of discussion relates to the Chinese EFL learner writers' misuse of two patterns in this set (PA18, and PA19), which were not found in expert writing (LL = 5.09, LL = 15.28). These two patterns were characterised by 'Definiens' being in the initial position while Source being inserted into the clause as an adjunct between Definiens and Definiendum. The learner writers' misuse of these two patterns could possibly be explained by their limited discoursal capacity to manage the information organisation in academic writing. From the perspective of information structure in SFL (Halliday & Matthiessen, 2014), 'Definiens' in these patterns normally carry the *Given* information while 'Definiendum' the *New*; however, the *Given-New* information flow in instances realising PA18 and PA19 was interrupted by an inserted element indicating the source, as illustrated in Example (6). Such interrupted information flow might be a hindrance not only to the crafting of a cohesive and coherent discourse but also to the accessibility and readability of the text, which may be considered inappropriate and consequently never used by expert writers.

(6) … there is also linguistic analysis at the discourse practice level that Fairclough calls "intertexual analysis". (COMATAL)

4.4. Set 3: introducing definition with an initiator

Set 3 includes two patterns (i.e., PA20 and PA21) in which the definition is introduced by an 'Initiator'. In our analyses, 'Initiator' is usually marked by definitional nouns, such as *concept*, *definition*, *notion*, etc. It was observed that the Chinese EFL learner writers' and the expert writers' use of these two patterns was of similar frequency and no statistically significant difference was observed (LL = 1.99, LL = 3.27). One possible interpretation of this finding is that the learner writers might have adequately grasped the usage of the definitional nouns, so that they were able to appropriately deploy them to create ostensive definitions in their academic writing (Flowerdew, 1992).

However, a closer look into instances of these two patterns revealed that, similar to what we have found about the use of 'Source', the Chinese EFL learner writers in some cases tended to realise 'Initiator' by a coordinate clause preceding the definitional clause rather than as part of a nominal phrase, which rendered their definitions unnecessarily lengthy and lexically redundant, as shown in Example (7).

(7) *So the definition can be revised as follows*: Euphemism is both a figure of speech and an indirect speech act, which … (COMATAL)

4.5. Set 4: delimiting the scope of a definition

The fourth set of analyses includes five patterns (i.e., PA 22, PA23, PA24, PA25, and PA26) in which the writers delimit the extent to which a given definition is valid or applicable through an element labelled 'Scope'. In our corpora, 'Scope' is usually realised by phrases such as *in the present study*, *in this paper*, *in our study*, etc. The use of 'Scope' allows the writers to hedge their definition, emphasising that a definition has only a local reference, not necessarily applicable on a wider scale (Pearson, 1998). It was found that those patterns with 'Scope' were rather frequently employed by the Chinese EFL learner writers (except for PA24), as compared with expert writers. This seems to suggest that these learner writers tended to adopt a more tentative and less assertive voice by using more hedged definitions, which allowed them to acknowledge the possibility of alternative interpretation and understanding. It is interesting to note that only PA24 (Definiendum – Hinge – Scope – Definiens – Supporting-statement) was significantly underused (or more precisely, never used) by the learner writers (LL = 10.55, $p < 0.01$). The peculiarity of PA24 lies in the location of Scope in terms of its sentential position. As previously reported in Zhang and Su (2022), 'Scope' may occur either in the initial or middle position of a definition sentence. It is further shown in this study that when 'Scope' occurs in the middle position, expert writers would flexibly place it either before or after the 'Hinge', whereas the learner writers tended to fix the position of 'Scope' before the 'Hinge', which may account for their underuse of PA24 and overuse of the other patterns in this set.

5. Discussion and implications

In Section 4 we discussed the major findings drawn from our local grammar based investigation into the Chinese EFL learners' pragmatic performance of the discourse act of definition in MA thesis writing, with that of expert writers in published research articles as reference for comparison. In this section, we further discuss the implications of our findings to EAP writing research and pedagogy.

As with Su et al. (2022), the present study has further demonstrated that local grammar can be a viable approach to exploring EFL learner writers' pragmatic performance of discourse acts in academic writing and diagnosing the problems they are likely to have. Specifically, Su et al. (2022) observed that the Chinese EFL learners were less aware of the strategy of exemplifying by citing relevant studies as well as the use of performative verbs (e.g., *illustrate, exemplify*) when performing the act of exemplification. Similarly, despite the fact that the Chinese EFL learners used much more frequently definition in MA theses than expert writers did in research articles, the current investigation revealed that they also had several problems (e.g., overuse of definition, redundant realisation of Source and

Initiator, misuse of two local grammar patterns) when performing definition in academic writing. Bringing these two studies together would suggest that Chinese EFL learners, to varying degrees, have difficulties performing discourse acts in academic writing, which may also be true for EFL learners of other L1 backgrounds. Given that appropriate performance of discourse acts is instrumental to the construction and dissemination of knowledge across disciplinary contexts, we thus argue that in EAP writing research more efforts should be made to explore how EFL learners of different L1 backgrounds perform such discourse acts in academic writing practice. Research of this kind will help unravel the problems and challenges EFL learners may encounter on their way to expert-like writing proficiency. Furthermore, findings of such research could have significant pedagogical implications in a wider context, which will be discussed below.

First, the current investigation suggests that, in the teaching and learning of EAP writing, it is important for teachers to help students develop a critical awareness of genre variation and potential target readership and draw their attention to the pragmatic dimensions of academic writing, especially the appropriate performance of discourse acts. As discussed above, our findings show that the Chinese EFL learner writers used definition far more frequently than expert writers did, which might be attributed to the average length, structural organisation, and different readership of the genres – published research articles are for peer researchers/specialists whereas MA theses are for thesis examiners. To raise EFL learners' awareness of genre variation and target readership, EAP instructors could, for instance, guide students to identify and count the definitions they find in their own writing, compare their definitions with those found in expert writing, and then critically discuss the similarities and differences between their uses of definitions. More importantly, learners need to be guided to distinguish genuine definitions from the less informative or fake ones (e.g., *language is part of culture* …), and to further explore how to define in more effective ways. We believe that such pedagogical practice has the potential to substantially promote EFL learners' awareness of genre and target readership, enabling the students to make appropriate adjustments in enacting the act of definition (e.g., remove unnecessary definitions and retain the proper ones), which is crucial especially when they attempt to transfer their MA theses into research articles or engage in more advanced writing tasks. Such pedagogical practice can also be applied to the teaching and learning of other discourse acts, which can enhance their awareness of writer-reader interaction and ultimately help EFL learners improve their academic writing proficiency.

Second, our findings suggest that it is pertinent to raise EFL learner writers' awareness towards the connection between meaning (or function) and patterning and, more importantly, the prototypicality of the patterns in realising a discourse act. In the case of definition, our investigation revealed both similarities and differences between the Chinese EFL learners' and expert writers' discourse-semantic realisations of definition in academic texts. For example, we found that the learner writers used five local grammar patterns at a similar frequency with expert writers, most notably the two patterns that involve the use of definitional nouns, indicating their adequate control over these meaning-making resources; at the same time, the learner writers were observed to overuse 18 patterns, misuse two patterns and underuse one pattern, as compared with expert writers (see Section 4). Based on these findings, we suggest that EAP writing teachers not only provide students with lexico-grammatical items that are most frequent in academic discourses but also make explicit to them how these resources can be appropriately patterned to fulfil particular functions and what variations these patterns permit when fitted into specific contexts or different genres (see also Durrant & Mathews-Aydınlı, 2011).

Additionally, our findings could provide fresh insights into EAP writing teachers' provision of written corrective feedback (WCF). Previous discussion on L2 WCF was mainly concerned with issues such as logic, accuracy, or grammatical errors in student writing samples (see Kang and Han (2015) and Crosthwaite et al. (2022) for comprehensive reviews). Limited attention has been paid to the discoursal or pragmatic aspects. In this study, we are able to identify many places where the Chinese EFL learners' use of definition could be improved by adopting or imitating the practices of the expert writers. In this regard, our findings are likely to lend a useful basis for the affordances of pragmatically-informed WCF in academic writing contexts. For instance, in our study, the Chinese EFL learner writers were observed to misuse two local grammar patterns of definition in their MA theses which never occurred in expert writing. In addition, they were also found to differ significantly from expert writers in the realisation of 'Source' and 'Initiator" (see Section 4.3 and 4.4 for more discussion). Therefore, when providing WCF on student writing samples, teachers can highlight those undesirable patterns associated with a given discourse act in student writing and then offer alternative ones that are more frequently used by expert writers in the field. Take Example (6) as an example. Students can be advised to revise it into *"intertextual analysis" refers to linguistics analysis at the discourse practice level (Fairclough, 1992)*, enacting PA6 which was more favourable in expert writing. Similarly, teachers can also underline student writers' redundant use of 'Source' and 'Initiator' and advise them to abridge their definitions into more succinct and concise forms. For example, Example (5) can be modified as *The concept of diglossia was originally defined by Ferguson (1959: 336) as a relatively stable language situation in which* …

To recapitulate, raising EFL learners' awareness of genre and target readership could help to enhance their awareness of writer-reader interaction; and providing them with the local grammar patterns associated with a given discourse act can equip them with the ways to perform that target discourse act in accord with the conventions of their disciplinary community. It is in these respects that we argue that employing a local grammar approach to investigate EFL learners' pragmatic performance of discourse acts in academic writing could contribute to EAP writing research and pedagogy, especially in EFL contexts.

6. Conclusion

In this study we reported on a local grammar based investigation into Chinese EFL learners' pragmatic performance of definition in MA thesis writing, with expert writers' performance in published research articles as reference for comparison. Detailed local grammar analyses of the two corpora have unveiled both similarities and differences between the two groups of writers' use of definition in their academic writing. These observations not only bring us to a more nuanced understanding of the Chinese EFL learners' pragmatic performance of definition in academic writing, but also provide several new insights into EAP writing research and pedagogy. In

particular, we highlighted the importance of raising EFL learners' critical awareness towards genre variation and target readership, introducing them to the appropriateness and prototypicality of discourse-semantic patterns in performing the target discourse act, and providing them with pragmatically-informed WCF on their writing samples in practice.

As discussed in previous studies, appropriate performance of communicative or discourse acts contributes substantially to the quality of academic writing and as such the teaching and learning of these acts is, and should always be, an indispensable component of EAP writing pedagogy (Fang, 2021; Jordan, 1999; Kirszner & Mandell, 2017; Widdowson & Allen, 1985). Findings of the current investigation, however, reinforce the observation made in previous research that EFL learners usually have problems performing discourse or communicative acts in academic writing (e.g., Hinkel, 2004; Paquot, 2008; Su et al., 2022), which points to the need to systematically diagnose the problems or challenges EFL learners may have when performing such acts in writing practice. Since currently efforts have only been made to explore Chinese EFL learners' pragmatic performance of exemplification and definition, there is an urgent need for future research to inquire into other discourse acts and/or in other EFL contexts. Doing so could help portray a fuller picture of EFL learners' pragmatic performance of discourse or communicative acts, findings of which could have important pedagogical implications for EAP writing research and pedagogy, as has been discussed in Section 5. We hope to have demonstrated in this paper that local grammars can be a possible and promising route via which these can be taken forward.

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Statement

The study reported in this paper has not been published previously or submitted for consideration in any other journals.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Yimin Zhang: Data curation, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing. **Hang Su:** Conceptualization, Funding acquisition, Project administration, Writing – review & editing.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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